

Session 28: A Tale of Two Seeds

Key Takeaways

- Lemek's actions intensify and spread the destruction and bloodshed that began with Cain and the snake.
- Genesis 4 makes it clear that the theme of the two seeds from Genesis 3 will be an ongoing conflict.

From Cain to Seth: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 4:17-26

Birth Scene #2: Cain's City

17 **and Cain knew his wife**
and she conceived, and gave birth to Enoch;
and he built a city,
and called the name of the city "Enoch (חנוך • *khanok*)," according to the name of his son.
18 and to Enoch was born Irad,
and Irad birthed Mehuyael,
and Mehuyael birthed Methushael,
and Methushael birthed Lamech.

The Murderous Lamech

- a 19 and Lamech took for himself two wives:
b the name of the one was **Adah** ,
b' and the name of the other **Zillah** .
-
- a 20 and **Adah** gave birth to **Yabal** ;
b **he was the father** of those who **dwelt in tents and have livestock** .
a' 21 and his brother's name was **Yubal** ;
b' **he was the father** of all those who **play the lyre and pipe** .
a 22 and **Zillah** , she also gave birth to **Tubal-Cain** ,
b **the forger** of all implements **of bronze and iron** ;
c and the sister of Tubal-cain was Naamah.

23 and Lamech said to his wives,

- a " **Adah** of and **Zillah** , **listen to my voice**
- b wives of Lamech, **hear my speech**,
- a for I have killed a **man** **for wounding me** ;
- a' and a **boy** **for striking me** ;
- b 24 if Cain is avenged **seven times**,
- b' then Lamech **seventy-seven times**."

Birth Scene #3: God "Appoints" a Son

25 **and Adam knew his wife again**
and she gave birth to a son,
 and she named him " Seth (שֵׁת)," because,
 "God has appointed (שָׂת) me another seed in place of Abel, for Cain killed him."

26 and to Seth, to him also a son was born;
 and he called his name Enosh.
 then it was begun, to call on the name of Yahweh.

The Cain and Abel Story. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom Adam to Noah (2020).

The Murderous Lemek: 4:19-24

Lemek is the seventh generation from Adam through Cain, and his life culminates and distorts two God-given realities in the narrative.

1. God provides the woman for the human in Genesis 2, but Lemek takes two wives for himself.
2. God provides Cain with mercy and a mark of protection, but Lemek declares his own mark of protection.

Lemek has three sons from his two wives, and each is associated with the development of human civilization in important ways. All three sons' names are wordplays from two Semitic roots "water canal" (*yabal*) or "tribute offering" (*yobil/yubal*). Each of the three sons is titled the "father" of a cultural institution. The narrative is highlighting the origins of human civilization and its diverse institutions.

Son 1: *Yabal* (יָבֵל)

Meaning of Name: "Stream, river" (see [Isa. 30:25](#); [44:4](#)) or "tribute, offering" (see [Zephaniah 3:10](#)). Description: "Father of those dwelling in tents and among herds" Cultural Institution: Animal husbandry on a mass scale

Son 2: *Yubal* (יֹבֵל)

Meaning of Name: "Water course, canal" (see [Jer. 17:8](#)) or "tribute, offering" (see [Isa. 18:7](#)). Description: "Father of those using the harp and the flute" Cultural Institution: Musical art

Son 3: *Tubal-Cain* (תּוֹבֵל קַיִן)

Meaning of Name: “Tribute offering of Cain” Description: “Hammerer of those fashioning with iron and bronze” Cultural Institution: Metallurgy

This account would have stood in contrast to Israel’s surrounding neighbors and their accounts for the origins of animal husbandry, music, and metallurgy. These are all viewed as divine wisdom received from the gods.

“[T]he development of the arts of civilization in the ancient Near East was typically attributed to the gods. [In Mesopotamian mythology] they were introduced to the human race by the seven divine sages (called the apkallu). In the Myth of Inanna and Enki, the patron goddess of Uruk, attempts to procure the arts of civilization from Enki, the lord of Eridu. Among the ninety-four ‘arts’ mentioned in the text are offices such as kingship and priesthood; objects such as sword and quiver; actions such as running, kissing, and lovemaking; qualities such as heroism or dishonesty; and abstractions such as understanding and knowledge. But pertinent to this passage, the list also includes the craft of the coppersmith (along with other crafts), the resounding lute and the art of singing, and the sheepfold.”

Walton, John H. (2001). [*Genesis: Zondervan Illustrated Bible Backgrounds Commentary Vol. 1*](#). Zondervan Academic.

“In the end, city building was a divine enterprise. Within this tradition, city building was related to, and a part of, creation, because creation involved the establishment of the world as the Mesopotamians knew it—not only in terms of the physical cosmos, but also including the civilized aspect of the social and economic world. In contrast, Genesis sees city building in purely human terms.”

Walton, John H. (2001). [*Genesis: Zondervan Illustrated Bible Backgrounds Commentary Vol. 1*](#). Zondervan Academic.

“[T]he Mesopotamians believed that humankind was initially barbaric and primitive. Civilization, consisting of cities, kingship, arts, sciences and technology, among other things, was a gift from the gods, given to humans by the gods. Once humans received these civilizing elements from the gods, they moved beyond their initial state of primitivism and became civilized. For many of these cultural rudiments, the creator god and god of wisdom Enki is said to have passed them to humans, and the apkallu were often the instruments of this transmission. The Mesopotamians spoke of these cultural components as the M’E , a term used to quantify in concrete terms their conception of the various aspects of civilization.”

Lowry, Daniel D. (2013). [*Toward a Poetics of Genesis 1-11*](#). Eisenbrauns.

Lemek’s third son’s name, Tubal-Cain, is a reference to Cain the murderer. Additionally, Tubal-Cain is associated with metallurgy—information we are given right before his father’s murderous song infers an ominous and dark tone to Tubal-Cain’s “metal work.” This brings to mind a sword, which is precisely the interpretation offered in ancient Jewish tradition (see *Genesis Rabbah* 22:2-3).

The literary design of Genesis 4 leads the reader to view the advent of the city and metallurgy as highly ambiguous, or even negative, developments because of their association with the murderous violence of Cain and Lemek.

- 4:1-16: Cain’s murder of his brother is avenged seven times
 - 4:17: Cain’s son/city Enoch is a civilization that multiplies murder
 - 4:21-22: Lemek’s son Tubal-Cain creates a civilization that invents weapons

- 4:22-23: Lemek's murder of a young man is avenged seventy-seven times

Sinai Legislation Mirrors Genesis 4:23

Genesis 4:23 NIV*

I have killed a man for **wounding** (פצע) me;
and a young man for **bruising** me (חבורה).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Exodus 21:23-25 Instructor's Translation

²³ But if there is any injury, then you shall assign: life for life, ²⁴ eye for eye, tooth for tooth, hand for hand, foot for foot, ²⁵ burn for burn, **wound** for **wound** (פצע), **bruise** for **bruise** (חבורה).

Lemek has both exceeded the divinely ordained limit of retaliation and redefined the divine law by his own authority. It is interesting that both Cain and Lemek's murders and the consequences are defined in the language of the later Sinai covenant laws.

Birth of Cain and Abel 4:1-2	Cain Murders Abel 4:3-16	Cain's Family Line 4:17-18	Lemek Murders Another 4:19-24	Birth of Seth to Replace Abel 4:25-26
"And the human knew Eve his wife and she conceived and gave birth..."		And Cain knew his wife, and she conceived and gave birth..."		And human again knew his wife and she gave birth..."
Eve boasts in her "divine" power (4:1) to create a "man" (איש)			Lemek boasts in his "divine" authority (4:24) to kill a "man" (איש)	Eve humbly receives the gift of another son (4:25)
	Narrative of murder and remorse		Narrative of murder and celebration	
	Cain's response is described in terms of Sinai covenant law about cities of refuge: Deut		Lemek's response is described in terms of Sinai covenant law about retaliation: Exodus 21:25	

Cain's and Lemek's Response. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Birth of Cain and Abel 4:1-2	Cain Murders Abel 4:3-16	Cain's Family Line 4:17-18	Lemek Murders Another 4:19-24	Birth of Seth to Replace Abel 4:25-26
	19:10-12 Seven times		Seventy-seven times	
Child is named in relation to Yahweh (4:1)		City is named in relation to humans ("the name of his son" 4:17)		Child named in relation to God (4:26), resulting in true worship.
<i>Cain's and Lemek's Response.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).				

"Seventy-sevenfold [literally, 'seventy-seven'] /—that is, seventy-seven times as much. The number, needless to say, is not to be taken literally. Sevenfold means in perfect measure (see above, on v. 15); seventy-sevenfold signifies in overflowing measure, more than is due, many for one."

Cassuto, U. (1961). [A Commentary on the Book of Genesis \(Part I\): from Adam to Noah](#). Magnes Press.

"While Cain, Lamech's ancestor, would be avenged seven times over by God, Lamech takes it into his own hands to satisfy his desire for vengeance through a seventy-sevenfold retaliation. At this point, the principle of retributive justice is pushed to the point of becoming the caricature of itself. Moreover, there is a profound irony in Lamech's effrontery to refer to the divine protection of his ancestor Cain. As Lamech's 'immunity,' by contrast, is at the cost of unlimited violence, he has turned the divine grace to Cain into its ugly counterfeit ... Any trivial inconvenience is occasion for Lamech to yield to violence. What he demands is not an eye for an eye, but a life for a wound. Lamech's song is the last spasm, so to speak, of Cain's murder story ... bringing the horror of fratricide to its apex ... The clouds are gathering that will soon bring about the flood."

LaCocque, Andre (2008). [Onslaught Against Innocence: Cain, Abel, and the Yahwist](#). Cascade Books.

"Unlike his ancestor several generations earlier who felt the desperate need of divine protection, Lamech feels he is his own security. He can handle any difficulty or any mistreatment quite adequately by himself. If Cain is avenged only sevenfold, he will be avenged seventy-sevenfold. He has no scruples about taking the law into his own hands. Lamech's chief characteristics, in line with his irregular marriages, are not commendable. He is not only replete with a spirit of vindictiveness, but he is also a proud man who backs away from nobody and does not hesitate to kill anybody. Cain's mind-set now surfaces in his great-great-grandson."

Hamilton, Victor P. (1990). [The Book of Genesis \(New International Commentary on the Old Testament Series\) 1-17](#). Eerdmans.

"If Adah and Zillah watched with pride as their sons developed husbandry, music, and metalworking, they listened with horror to their husband's violent blood lust. Lamek's seventy-sevenfold vengeance stands in contrast with the law of talion which limits retaliation to exact equivalence (Exod. 21:25 "bruise for bruise," "hit for hit" echoes the terminology of Gen. 4:23 exactly). By placing this comment at the end of the story of Cain, the editor suggests that all his descendants are under judgment and hints at the disaster to come."

Wenham, Gordon J. (1987). [*Genesis 1-15 \(Word Biblical Commentary\)*](#). Thomas Nelson Inc.

Hope Reborn: The Arrival of Seth in Genesis 4:25-26

Genesis 4:25-26 Instructor's Translation

²⁵ And Adam knew his wife again, and she gave birth to a son, and she named him "Seth (שֵׁת)," because, "God has appointed (שָׂת) me another seed in place of Abel, for Cain killed him." ²⁶ And to Seth, to him also a son was born; and he called his name Enosh. Then it was begun, to call on the name of Yahweh.

In contrast to Cain's birth, which Eve attributed to her own creative powers ([Gen. 4:1-2](#)), and in contrast to Cain, who uses his son's name to memorialize his own city ([Gen. 4:17](#)), this chapter ends with a chastened Eve, who now highlights God's generosity in giving her another son to replace the murdered Abel (and, less directly, the exiled Cain).

This portrait of Seth as the substitute for Abel is crucial. It begins a design pattern motif that echoes from Genesis through 2 Kings.

- Seth is "in place of" (תחת) Abel
- The ram is offering "in place of" (תחת) Isaac
- Judah offers himself "in place of" (תחת) Benjamin

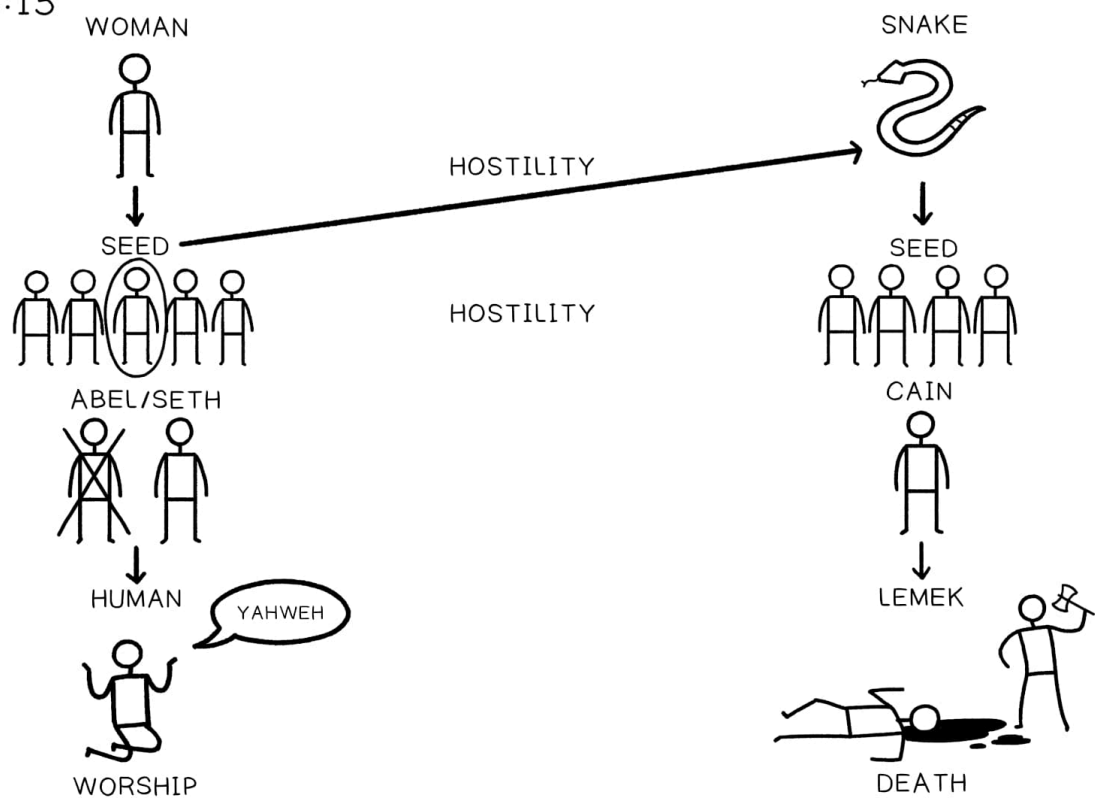
In contrast to Cain's son Enoch, Seth now has a son, Enosh (אֱנוֹשׁ), which means, "human." It's as if humanity gets a fresh start with Seth, which helps us understand the bright note on which this dark chapter concludes: the worship of Yahweh.

"The statement [is] saying that the worship of Yahweh began in the primeval time. With the birth of Seth, the child of promise, people started to invoke him. Beforehand, to be sure, Yahweh has intervened in the course of history ... But, properly speaking, no one had called on the name of God, that is, until the end of Genesis 4 there is no prayer ... Until Seth, it is here intimated, the humans had taken intercourse with the deity for granted ... With the advent of Seth, however, something has changed in the relationship ... the name of God can now be called upon for help and to honor ... What is of primordial import here is that ... the invocation of Yahweh preceded the advent of the people of Israel. It is a theological statement: Yahweh is the God of the whole of humanity ... Abram did not inaugurate the calling upon of Yahweh's name ... rather, Abram's conversion led him to join a chorus that began with Seth."

LaCocque, Andre (2008). [*Onslaught Against Innocence: Cain, Abel, and the Yahwist*](#). Cascade Books.

Illustration: Continuing the Tale of Two Seeds

GENESIS 3:15



Tale of Two Seeds Continued. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Comparing Cain’s Line and Seth’s Line

The two lines of Cain (Gen. 4:17-24) and Seth (Gen. 4:25-26, 5:1-32) are juxtaposed so that the reader notices all sorts of comparisons and contrasts.

Cain’s Line 4:17-24	Seth’s Line 4:25-26, 5:1-32
1. Adam (אדם)	0. God (+ repeat of 1:26-27) 1. Adam (אדם)
2. Cain (קין)	2. Seth (שֵׁת)
3. Enoch (חֲנוֹךְ)	3. Enosh (אֱנוֹשׁ = “humanity”)
4. Irad (עִירָד)	4. Kenan (קֵינָן)

Cain’s Line and Seth’s Line. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Cain's Line 4:17-24	Seth's Line 4:25-26, 5:1-32
5. Mehuya'el (מחויאל)	5. Mehalelel (מהללאל)
6. Methusha'el (מתושאל)	6. Yered (ירד)
7. Lemek I (למך) [70 x 7]	7. Enoch (חנוך = "dedicated")
8. Yabal	8. Methuselah (מתושלח)
9. Yubal	9. Lemek II (למך) [700 + 70 + 7yrs]
10. Tubal-Cain [= "Produce of Cain"] Three sons	10. Noah (נח) Three sons - Shem, Ham, Japheth
Lemek's perversion (4:23-24) Adam had 1 wife // Lemek has 2 wives Cain: divine blessing of 7x vengeance // Lemek: human curse of 7x + 70x vengeance	Lemek's promise (5:29) Noah (נח) will bring comfort (נחם) to our "painful toil" (עצבון) and the cursed ground (אדמה/אררה) → 3:17 Lemek lives 7 + 70 + 700 years.
Blessing becomes Curse	Curse becomes Blessing
Cain's Line and Seth's Line. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).	

"The effect of the whole of Genesis 5, is to replace Cain with Seth as the second father of humanity. The human race continued only through the lineage of Adam's third son, Seth, the descendants of his first son Cain presumably having perished in the flood ... Here we see a programmatic principle laid out ... as the people of Israel and its royal and priestly dynasties are not derived from their families first-born, but from late-born sons. The people are descended not from Ishmael and Esau, but from Isaac and Jacob. The royal line is derived from Jacob's fourth son, Judah, and from David and Solomon, none of whom are the first-born. The priesthood is derived from Levi, Jacob's third son, and the priest's third and fourth sons Ithamar and Eleazar, not Nadab and Abihu the first and second born. In Cain and Seth, we can see that the same principle pertains not only within the chosen family, but with universal humanity as a whole: humankind is descended not from Cain but from Seth, not from Adam and Eve's first son, but from their third ... In that case, Abel's death in the field is not final or irreversible, for upon it follows his assumption of the exalted status of ancestor of all who live. God's favor at the altar leads to more than fratricide. It leads also to the survival of the human family through the younger brother."

Levenson, Jon D. (1995). [*The Death and Resurrection of the Beloved Son: The Transformation of Child Sacrifice in Judaism and Christianity*](#). Yale University Press.

"The genealogy in Genesis 4:17-24 leading from Cain to Lamech, from one murderer to another, is by contrast an anti-genealogy, which expresses through the list the whole sequence of human decisions undertaken outside of the order established by God at creation. The use of the genealogy to link two murderers is highly ironic. Their actions in bringing life to an end contradict the whole logic of the genealogies, which normally record the orderly continuation of life from one generation to the next. The irony, in turn, highlights a fundamental theme in Genesis, that human sin stands in profound contradiction to the created order of God. Cain's and Lamech's murders subvert the very nature of genealogical succession, which rests on the command to be fruitful and multiply in Genesis 1:28. Significantly, the genealogy of Seth, which reasserts the created order, appears after the subversion of the genealogical order in chapter 4 so that the created order has the last word."

Robinson, Robert B. (1986). "The Literary Function of Genealogies in Genesis". *The Catholic Biblical Quarterly* Vol. 48 (4). Catholic Biblical Association.

"[C]omparing the two genealogies in Gen 4 and Gen 5... confirms our suspicions regarding the negative light cast on the first in contrast to the positive of the second. [T]he final editor juxtaposes these two genealogies for communicative effect... a "genealogical doublet": Whatever the origins of the two lines . . . the texts of Genesis 4 and 5, and particularly the recurrent similarity in names, invite an examination of their relationship. The text attaches Cain's Enoch to a city but Seth's Enoch moves beyond human culture to the world of the divine. . . . Both Lamechs play pivotal roles in their lines and both have statements recorded in the text. But Cain's Lamech utters a cry of vengeance and with that terminates his line; while Seth's Lamech expresses the hope for a better life for his descendants, and with that introduces the offspring who will continue his line and play a role in trying to fulfill his wish."

Lowry, Daniel D. (2013). [*Toward a Poetics of Genesis 1-11*](#). Eisenbrauns.

Reflection Question

Compare and contrast Cain with Lamech. How are their actions similar? Describe the trajectory the story takes while following Cain's descendants.